

Lab: Feeling the Boundary of Your Skin

Objective

Experience the system boundary through reflective journaling that reveals how the body defines and maintains the separation between self and world through the lens of pattern-feeling without numbers.

Prerequisites

- A quiet, comfortable space for 25 minutes
- Willingness to engage in reflective journaling
- No prior experience required

Part 1: Arriving (5 minutes)

Sit quietly with your journal. Take three slow breaths. Before writing anything, check in with your body. Notice any sensations, feelings, or subtle knowings that are present right now.

Now bring your attention to the boundary of your body. Where does the inside end and the outside begin? Through the lens of pattern-feeling without numbers, notice how this boundary is not static but alive and responsive.

Write your response here

(Describe your initial sense of the body boundary. Where is it most vivid? Where is it most vague?)

Part 2: Inside and Outside (5 minutes)

Alternate your attention between internal sensations (heartbeat, breath, warmth, gut) and external sensations (sounds, air, pressure). Through pattern-feeling without numbers, notice: the boundary between inside and outside is what makes you a system.

Write your response here

(What did you notice when switching between inside and outside? How did the lens of pattern-feeling without numbers change your awareness?)

Part 3: Boundary Perturbation (7 minutes)

Explore what happens when the boundary is disrupted. Apply something cool to your skin, use a tool to tap a surface (feeling through the tool), or shift your attention to where clothing meets skin. In 4E cognition, the system boundary can extend, sharpen, or shift.

Write your response here

(Describe how the boundary changed during each perturbation. Where did you feel the system most strongly?)

Part 4: Integration (5 minutes)

Return to stillness. Through the perspective of pattern-feeling without numbers, reflect on what you have experienced about systems and boundaries.

Write your response here

(What did you learn about systems that you could not learn from reading alone? How does pattern-feeling without numbers illuminate the concept of a system boundary?)

Reflection Table

Dimension	What I Noticed	Active Inference Connection
Initial awareness		Baseline generative model state
Embodied exploration		Prediction error through direct experience
Pattern-feeling without numbers lens		Course-specific perspective on systems
Integration		Updated understanding through bodily knowing

Discussion

Consider how pattern-feeling without numbers reveals aspects of systems that other perspectives might miss. In Active Inference, every perspective changes the precision weighting of different signals, revealing different dimensions of the same underlying process of free energy minimization.